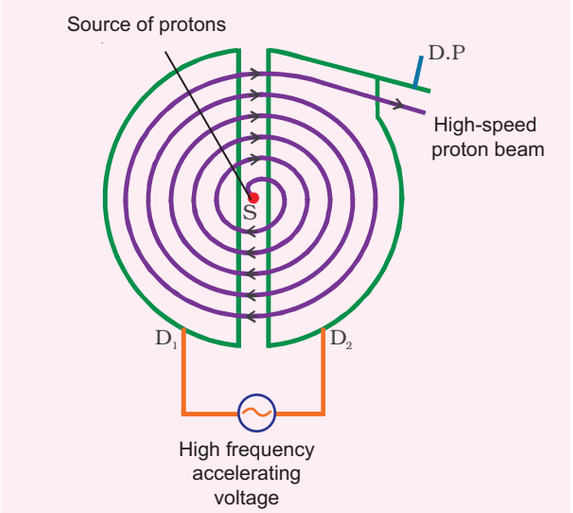


Figure 3.50 Working of cyclotron

Construction

The schematic diagram of a cyclotron is shown in Figure 3.50. The particles are allowed to move in between two semi-circular metal containers called Dees (hollow D - shaped objects). Dees are enclosed in an evacuated chamber and it is kept in a region with uniform magnetic field controlled by an electromagnet. The direction of magnetic field is normal to the plane of the Dees. The two Dees are kept separated with a gap and the source S (which ejects the particle to be accelerated) is placed at the centre in the gap between the Dees. Dees are connected to high frequency alternating potential difference.

Working

Let us assume that the ion ejected from source S is positively charged. As soon as ion is ejected, it is accelerated towards a Dee (say, Dee – 1) which has negative potential at that time. Since the magnetic field is normal to the plane of the Dees, the ion moves in a circular path. After one semi-circular path inside Dee-1, the ion reaches the gap between Dees. At this time, the polarities of the Dees are reversed so that the ion is now accelerated towards Dee-2 with a greater velocity. For this circular motion, the centripetal force on the charged particle q is provided by Lorentz force.

$$\frac{mv^2}{r} = qvB$$

$$\Rightarrow r = \frac{m}{qB}v$$

$$\Rightarrow r \propto v \qquad (3.63)$$

From the equation (3.63), the increase in velocity increases the radius of circular path. This process continues and hence the particle moves in spiral path of increasing radius. Once it reaches near the edge, it is taken out with the help of deflector plate and allowed to hit the target T.

The important condition in cyclotron operation is that when the frequency f at which the positive ion circulates in the magnetic field must be equal to the constant frequency of the electrical oscillator f_{osc}. This is called resonance condition.

From equation (3.60), we have

$$f_{osc} = \frac{qB}{2\pi m}$$

The time period of oscillation is

$$T = \frac{2\pi m}{qB}$$

The kinetic energy of the charged particle is

$$KE = \frac{1}{2}mv^2 = \frac{q^2B^2r^2}{2m} \qquad (3.64)$$

Limitations of cyclotron

(a) the speed of the ion is limited
(b) electron cannot be accelerated
(c) uncharged particles cannot be accelerated

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